



Piyush Goyal (right), Minister of Commerce & Industry; Consumer Affairs & Food & Public Distribution; and Textiles, with Siddharth Zarabi

industrial powerhouses of Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Maharashtra, besides the central government, spent a neat packet in an effort that can only be summed up as a pitch to a world that is looking for a hedge to China.

“In the seven years that I have been coming here, I don’t think I have seen this level of Indian representation at Davos,” is how Punit Renjen, the India-born Global CEO of professional services firm Deloitte, chose to comment on the effort.

Over 100 participants made for one of the largest recent Indian delegations ever at Davos. “In terms of numbers and specifically when it comes to government, we had record numbers from India,” said Sriram Gutta, Deputy Head of India and South Asia at the WEF.

The effort to talk up India’s poten-

tial as an investment prospect at Davos fits in with the much larger plan afoot at the trade policy level. Since 2019, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has embarked on a determined push to boost Indian exports and domestic manufacturing capacities through bilateral and regional trade pacts.

This change in strategy by the PM is being implemented with rigour by Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and Commerce Secretary B.V.R. Subrahmanyam. It has resulted in India pushing on the pedal for trade deals including the comprehensive economic partnership agreement with the UAE that was closed in record time.

Another economic cooperation agreement has been inked with Australia and negotiations are underway with the UK and Canada as well. The European Union has also reached out

to get greater access to the Indian market. In abject contrast, China’s much-vaunted Belt and Road Initiative has slowed down considerably and the Middle Kingdom’s crack-down on its tech giants has sent global investors scurrying to the exit.

It is no coincidence that Goyal, who led the Indian delegation at the WEF, headed straight to London from Davos for a two-day visit to hold discussions with UK Prime Minister Boris Johnson’s government on the proposed free trade agreement with the UK. There is a sense of urgency in the air—the leaders of the two nations have set a timeline of Diwali this year to finalise the pact.

This renewed focus on showcasing India’s rising economy and the opportunity it presents is getting noticed, even though China cannot be simply wished away by the rest of the world. Speaking with *Business Today* TV, Borge Brende, President, WEF, and former foreign minister of Norway, said he was very bullish on India in the medium to long run, even though there are growth challenges for the country, and the rest of the world, in the short term.

So, can India live up to the expectations and seize the moment?

Business leaders believe that global investors are looking favourably towards India. Deloitte’s Renjen said “this is India’s century”, adding that the realignment of global supply chains from a ‘just in time’ to a ‘just in case’ scenario presented an opportunity that was up for grabs. “It is important for India, both the central and state governments as well as businesses, to step up and seize the moment. By the way, China is going to be a potent competitor... But I think, India can compete,” he said, adding that he could smell *samosas* “while strolling down the promenade outside the India Lounge”.

But if the wafting smell of a *samosa* is hard to resist, it is perceptions about the ease of doing business that matter when it comes to investors